Pricing privacy

Demand for on-chain privacy is established. Whether it accrues to token holders depends on what each network sells, who pays for it, and where that value ends up.

Khala Research · November 2026 · Market data to 15 October 2026

COVERAGE UNIVERSE		HOW VALUE REACHES THE TOKEN
Zcash	Private money	Monetary asset
Aztec	Private smart contracts on Ethereum	Fee + stake
Umbra	Private balances and swaps on Solana	Governance
PersistentAI	Confidential AI agents for banks	No token
SN25 UR	Private connectivity on Bittensor	Reserve lock

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Privacy demand is real, but few tokens yet capture it for holders

1	Demand for on-chain confidentiality is now structural	$306B of stablecoins settles on transparent ledgers, the first confidential payroll and OTC trades were executed in 2026, and US policy has moved from sanctions to an approved privacy ETF.	**$306B** stablecoins on public ledgers
2	Markets reward privacy only where the token is the money	Transaction-privacy assets are valued at about $31B, while the network-privacy tokens we track are worth about $46M combined, because only the former are held as monetary assets.	**~670x** valuation gap between the two
3	Few privacy tokens connect usage to value accrual	Aztec's sequencers stake $12M against $58K of user funds, Umbra's fees accrue to a DAO treasury rather than to holders, and PersistentAI has no token.	**$58K** user funds secured on Aztec
4	SN25 UR offers the clearest path to closing the gap	URnetwork reports about 350K monthly users, and the operator-deposit mechanism that converts usage into SN25 demand is built and awaiting a non-zero reference rate.	**350K** monthly users (team-reported)

CATALYSTS TO WATCH | First operator deposit on SN25 | Aztec v6 and the 13 November unlock | Umbra's Nimbus network launch | Storm retrial, 26 April 2027

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SECTION 01

The case for privacy

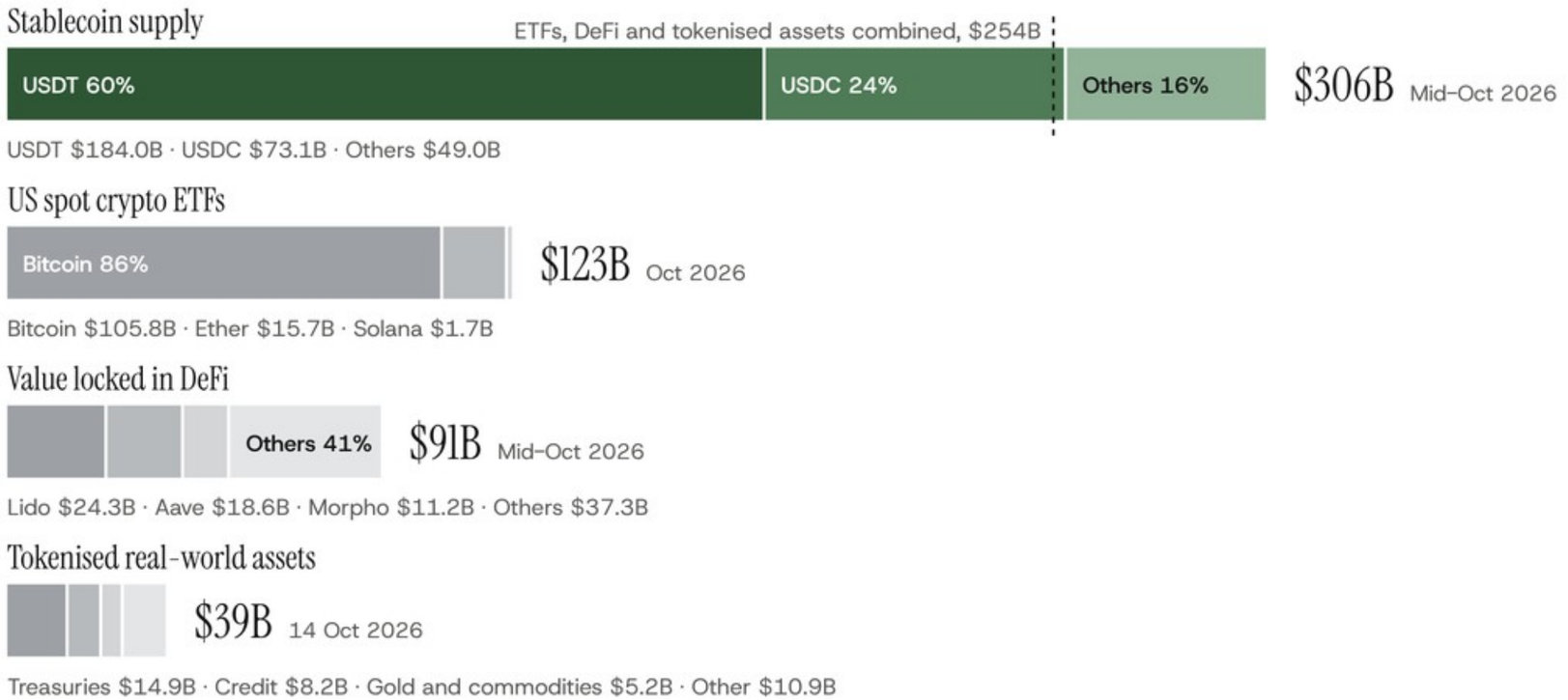
Corporate payment flows now settle on public ledgers, and the founders of the industry are building confidentiality into its base layer.

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$306B of stablecoins now settles on fully transparent ledgers

That exceeds crypto ETFs, DeFi and tokenised assets combined, and every transfer, balance and counterparty relationship is visible to anyone.



Capital in selected onchain financial products, USD. ETF figures are net assets; tokenised assets are distributed value.

Once an address is linked to a company, its payroll, supplier terms and treasury positions become public record.

Tether and Circle issue 84% of supply, so most activity runs through two contracts any analyst can monitor.

At this scale, confidentiality becomes an operating requirement for corporate treasuries rather than a user preference.

"For users that prioritize privacy, this could become a 'must-have' feature."

Zach Pandl, Head of Research, Grayscale, on AI and financial privacy, September 2026

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Buterin and Durov both treat privacy as core infrastructure, not a feature

The founders of Ethereum and of a messaging app with over a billion users reach the same conclusion from different starting points.



Vitalik Buterin

Co-founder

Ethereum

"Privacy is not about standing apart. It's about standing together."

Why I support privacy, 14 April 2025

Why it matters	Control over information is power, so privacy protects decentralisation, personal freedom and institutions such as the secret ballot.
Where it belongs	In the protocol itself, covering payments, application activity, chain reads and network-level anonymity.
Current gap	Largely a roadmap, with adoption dependent on wallets and applications implementing it.

Same conclusion



Pavel Durov

Founder and CEO

Telegram, over 1B monthly users

"Telegram would rather exit a market than undermine encryption with backdoors and violate basic human rights."

Telegram channel, 21 April 2025

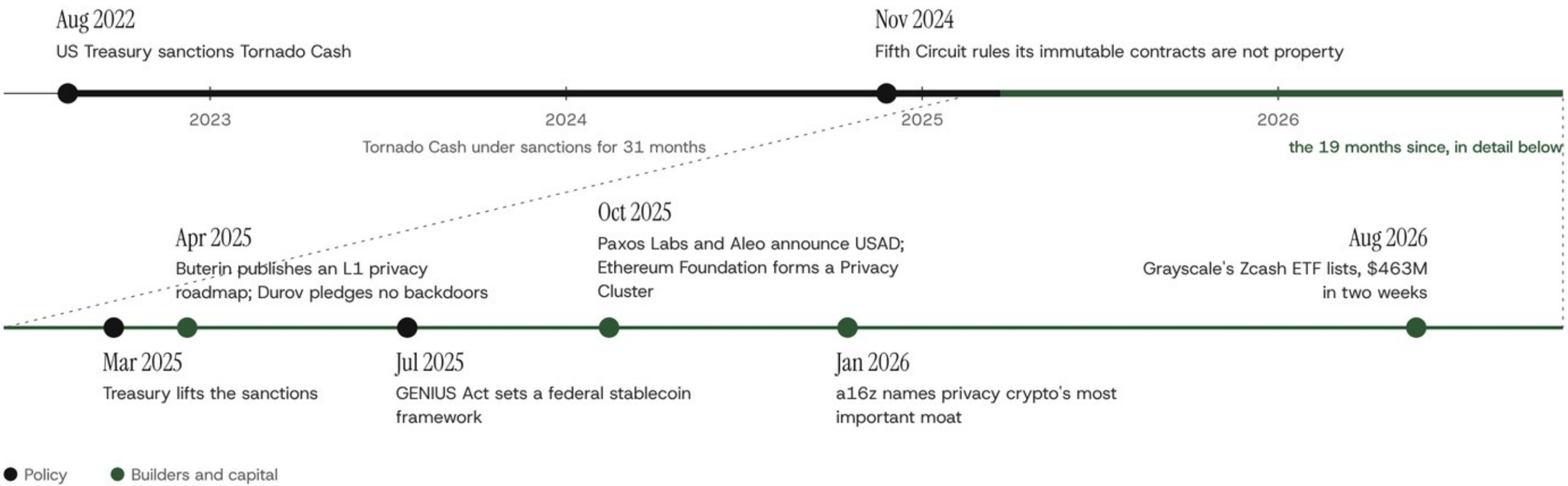
Why it matters	Encryption protects everyday communication and personal safety, and any access built for authorities is also available to attackers.
Where it belongs	In the product, with no backdoors, even at the cost of withdrawing from a market.
Current gap	Telegram's default Cloud Chats are not end-to-end encrypted; only Secret Chats are.

Implication Both positions point to privacy embedded at the infrastructure layer from the outset, which favours protocols over standalone privacy applications.

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In four years the US moved from sanctioning Tornado Cash to listing a Zcash ETF

Sanctions were lifted, builders returned and institutional capital followed, although developer liability remains unresolved.



Upper axis to scale from mid-2022; lower axis expands March 2025 to October 2026. Developer liability is still open: Roman Storm's retrial is set for April 2027.

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Payroll and trading lead adoption because disclosure there is most costly

Encrypting amounts is not sufficient on its own, because the network connection can still reveal who is transacting.

Use case	What must stay private	Evidence so far	Who is building or backing it
Payments and payroll *Company-reported deployments*	Salaries, supplier invoices and treasury movements	Bron paid salaries in confidential USDT on Ethereum mainnet through Zama, January 2026	Zama · Bron · Aleo
Trading and tokenised assets *Company-reported deployments*	Orders, positions and holdings	GSR executed a confidential OTC trade on the Zama protocol, March 2026; Dfns added confidential tokens to its wallet platform	Zama · Dfns · Pantera *investor*
Private computation and AI *NEAR AI live; others building*	Customer data and model inputs	NEAR AI Cloud runs confidential inference with an attestation per request; secure-hardware and MPC networks are building	NEAR AI · Seismic · a16z *investor* · Nillion · Hack VC *investor*
Programmable privacy *Building*	Hidden inputs for sealed-bid auctions, private ballots and strategy games	Reusable tools, so each application does not need its own cryptography	Fhenix · Zama · Multicoin *investor* · Aztec · Noir

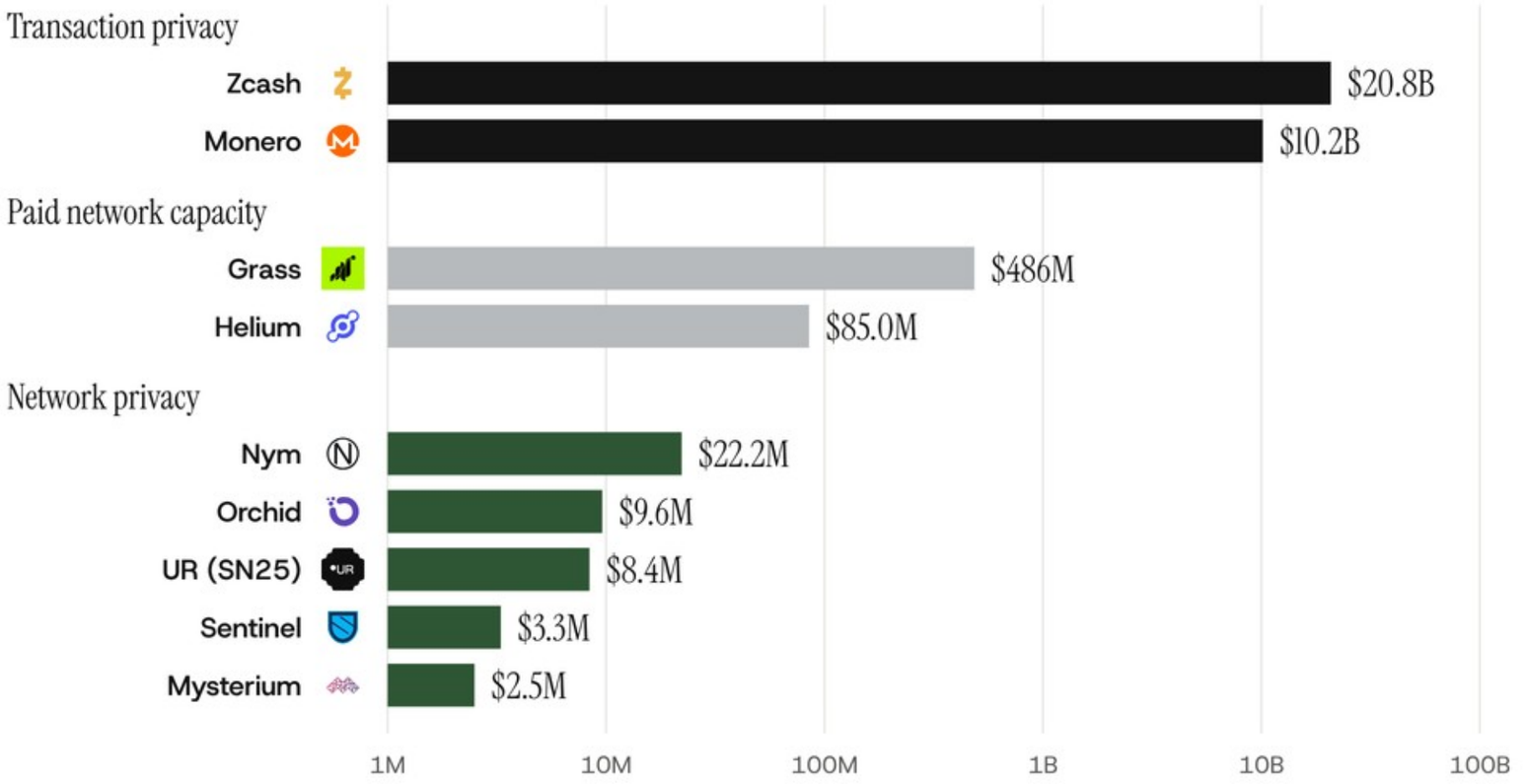
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Markets have assigned material value to privacy only where the token itself functions as money

Transaction-privacy assets command multi-billion valuations, while networks that sell privacy as a service are valued in the tens of millions.

Grass and Helium show the alternative route to value: both also sell network capacity, but paying customers and token-level value capture support materially higher valuations.

This report applies the same test to each token in our coverage universe.



Market cap, USD, log scale. CoinGecko and MEXC, 15 October 2026.

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SECTION 02

Value capture across the coverage universe

What each privacy network sells, who pays for it, and how much of that value reaches the token.

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Privacy token landscape

Privacy is not one product. These networks sell different kinds of it to different buyers, and their tokens capture value in different ways.

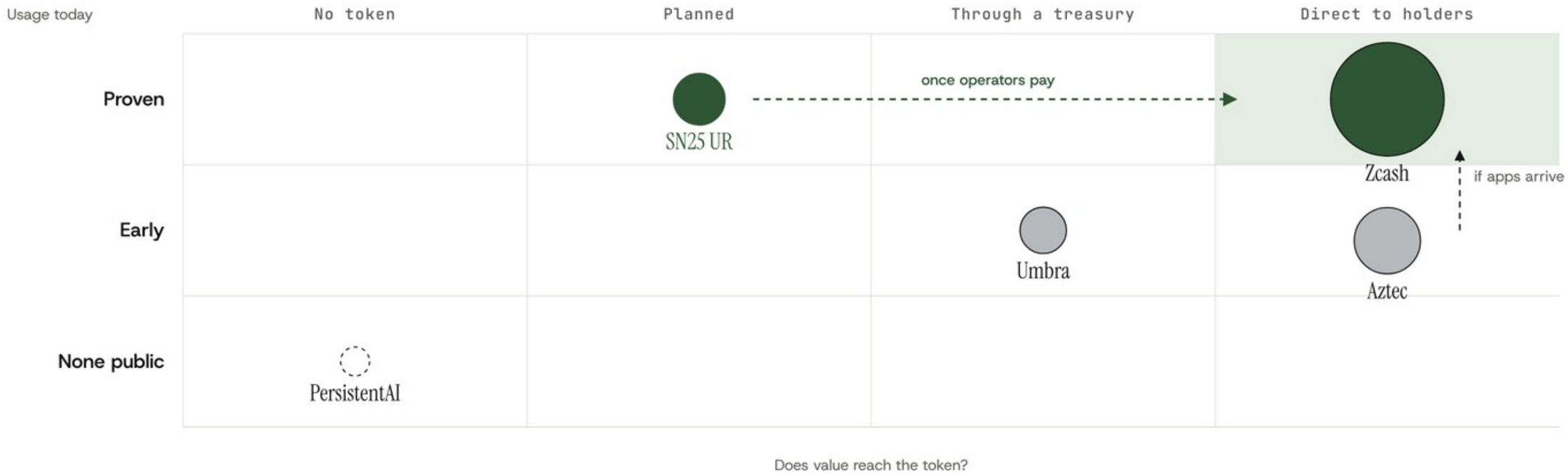
Zcash sells private money. Aztec and Umbra sell private use of Ethereum and Solana. PersistentAI sells agent software to banks. SN25 UR, the new entrant, sells private connectivity.

	Zcash	Aztec	Umbra	PersistentAI	SN25 UR New entrant
What it produces	Private money: shielded ZEC transfers that hide sender, recipient, amount and memo	Ethereum L2 for private smart contracts: confidential balances, state and execution	Private balances, transfers and swaps for existing Solana assets	FireFlow, agent execution for financial institutions: memory, permissions, approvals and audit replay	Bandwidth and routing marketplace: independent providers carry traffic, validators score performance
Who pays for it	Senders pay fees; block rewards fund security, but issuance is a subsidy, not customer revenue	Users pay fees or apps sponsor them; operator rewards are partly token emissions	Users pay protocol fees and relayer tips; protocol revenue accrues to the DAO treasury	Financial institutions, via a four-week assessment then staged rollout; no public pricing or revenue	Customers pay operators; URnetwork sells UR Pro at $5/month, which is not subnet revenue
Does value reach the token	Monetary asset ZEC is the money, the fee and the mining reward; 21M cap. The thesis is demand to hold	Fee + stake $AZTEC buys fees and stakes sequencers; congestion fees burn, the rest pays operators	Governance $UMBRA governs the treasury via MetaDAO markets; no automatic buyback or dividend	No token No native token found; Aztec link unverified and would cover settlement, not agent data	Reserve lock Operators are expected to buy UR and lock it in reserve; documented, not enforced

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Zcash alone combines proven demand with direct value accrual, while UR has the demand but not yet the mechanism

Each token is placed by the usage it can demonstrate and how directly that usage accrues to the token. Circle size reflects market value.



Khala Research placement. Market data 14 to 15 October 2026; UR users team-reported; Aztec usage from L2BEAT.

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Zcash's valuation reflects demand for the option of privacy rather than its current use

The shielded share of supply rose through 2025 before retreating in 2026.

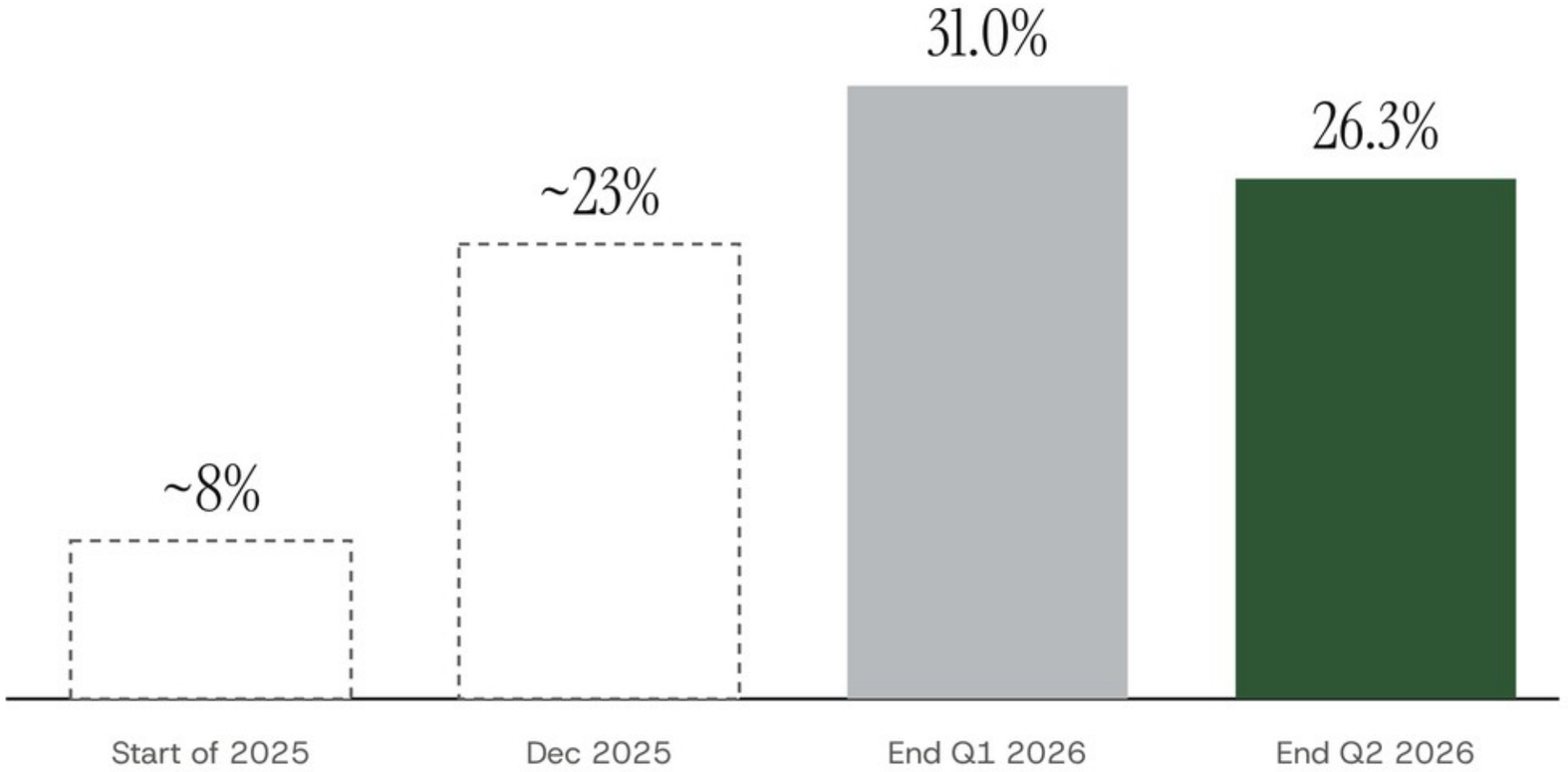
ZEC trades at roughly twice Monero's market value and is held in a US-listed ETF, yet most network activity still settles on the transparent side.

Investors are paying for optionality on private use that has yet to materialise at scale.

Q2 2026 network fees



Transparent ~$92K Shielded ~$18K

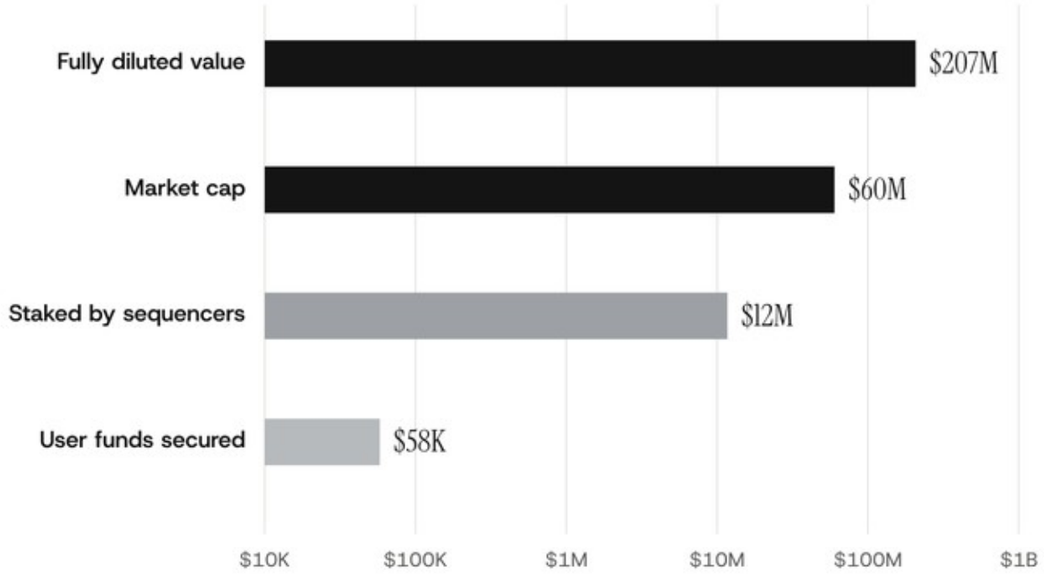


Share of ZEC supply held in shielded pools. approximate reported latest

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Aztec's sequencers have staked $12M to secure only $58K of user funds

Aztec has the most complete token design in the group, but usage has yet to arrive and the current release carries a disclosed critical vulnerability.



What it sells

Private smart contracts on Ethereum: confidential balances, state and execution, written in Noir.

How value reaches the token

Fees are paid in AZTEC, congestion fees burn, and sequencers must stake 200,000 AZTEC to produce blocks.

What has to be true

v6 closes the proving bug disclosed on 7 August, and apps bring user funds well above today's $58K.

Supply risk

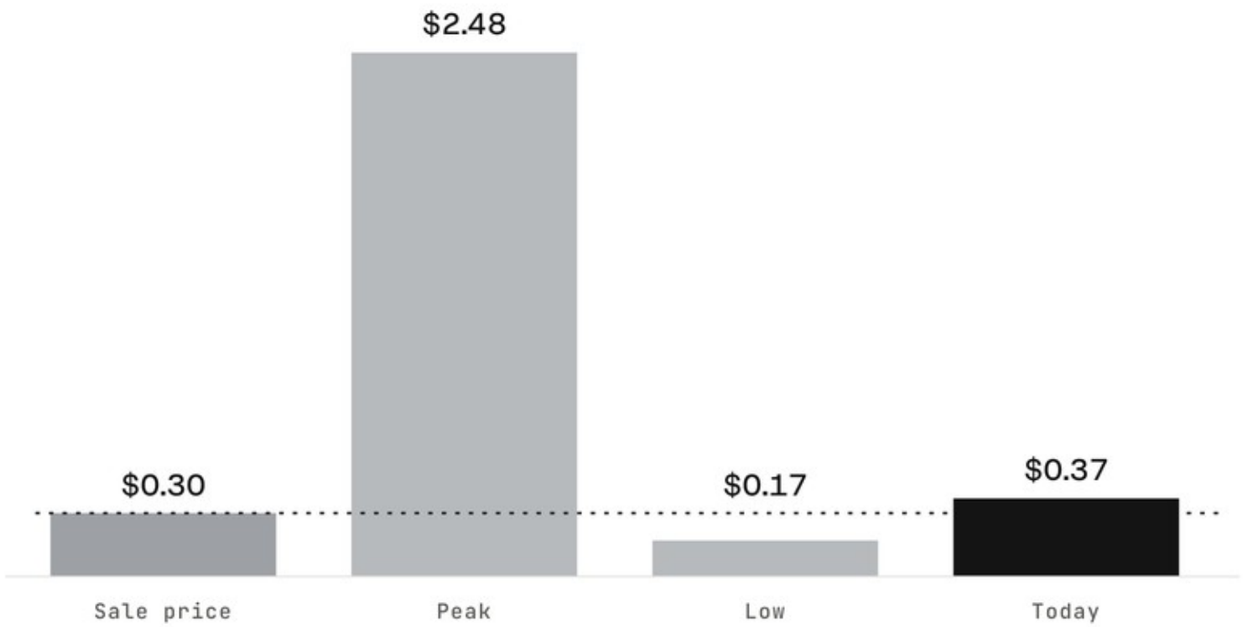
Only 29% is circulating, the Foundation unlocks on 13 November, and governance can mint up to 20% of supply a year.

Price $0.020 and supply 10.35B (CoinDesk, 14 October 2026); circulating supply and unlocks (Tokenomist); staking, value secured and minting limit (L2BEAT, 16 October 2026); vulnerability notice (Aztec, 7 August 2026).

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Umbra ties team vesting to price targets, but holders have no direct claim on fees

Umbra sells private balances, transfers and swaps on Solana, and its token governs a treasury rather than collecting fees.



What it sells

A private wallet for Solana assets with screening and viewing keys; Nimbus, its network for other apps, is coming soon.

How value reaches the token

Fees go to a DAO treasury that UMBRA holders steer through MetaDAO markets. There is no automatic buyback or dividend.

Why the vesting matters

Team and adviser tokens unlock only when fully diluted value reaches 2x, 4x, 8x, 16x and 32x the $0.30 sale price.

What has to be true

Nimbus brings other apps onto Umbra and deposits grow well beyond today's $187K.

Price, market cap $5.2M, fully diluted $10.2M and deposits (DefiLlama, 15 October 2026); sale terms (MetaDAO; The Block, 10 October 2025); vesting (Blockworks token transparency filing, 29 September 2026). Not the Ethereum stealth-address project of the same name.

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SECTION 03

SN25 UR and the network privacy opportunity

An established user base, with a mechanism for converting usage into token demand that is built but not yet switched on.

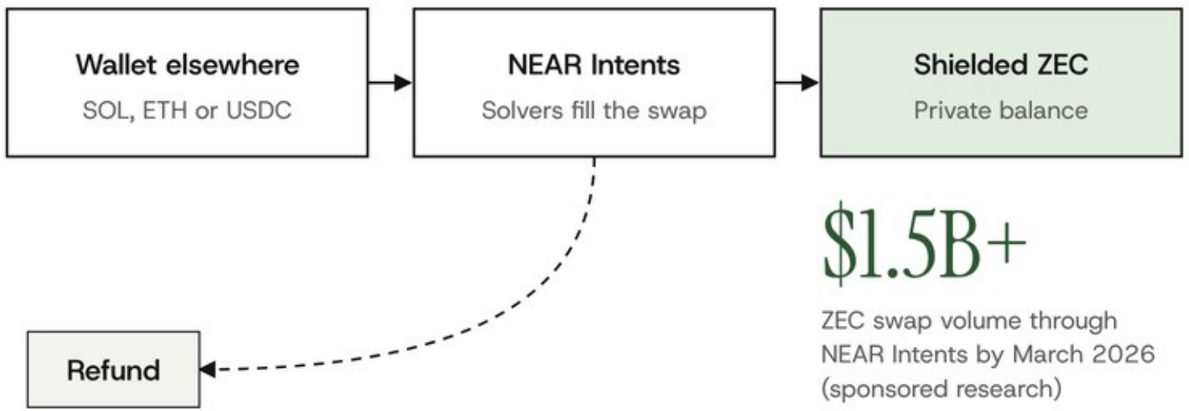
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In controlled tests, network timing alone linked more than 95% of wallet users to their IP addresses

Only five of the 18 privacy projects we track protect who the user is, and transaction privacy fails where funds cross chains and where a wallet connects to the network.

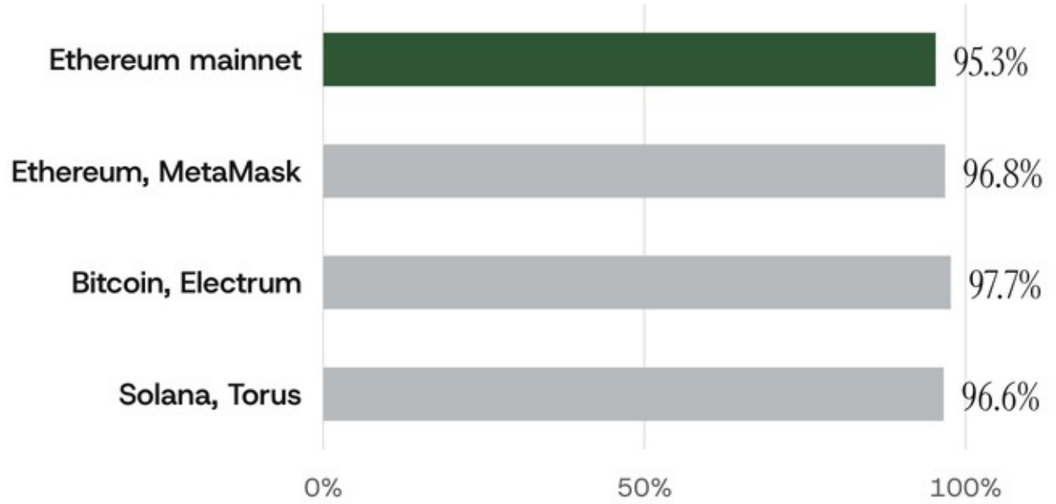
Crossings leak: the swap route into private Zcash



$1.5B+

ZEC swap volume through NEAR Intents by March 2026 (sponsored research)

Connections leak: wallet users a passive observer identified



Wang et al., arXiv preprint, experiments March to April 2025. The observer watches traffic at internet exchanges or provider routers. Bitcoin and Solana rows ran on testnets. The authors name Tor or VPNs as possible defences.

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URnetwork reached about 350K monthly users before any operator deposit on SN25

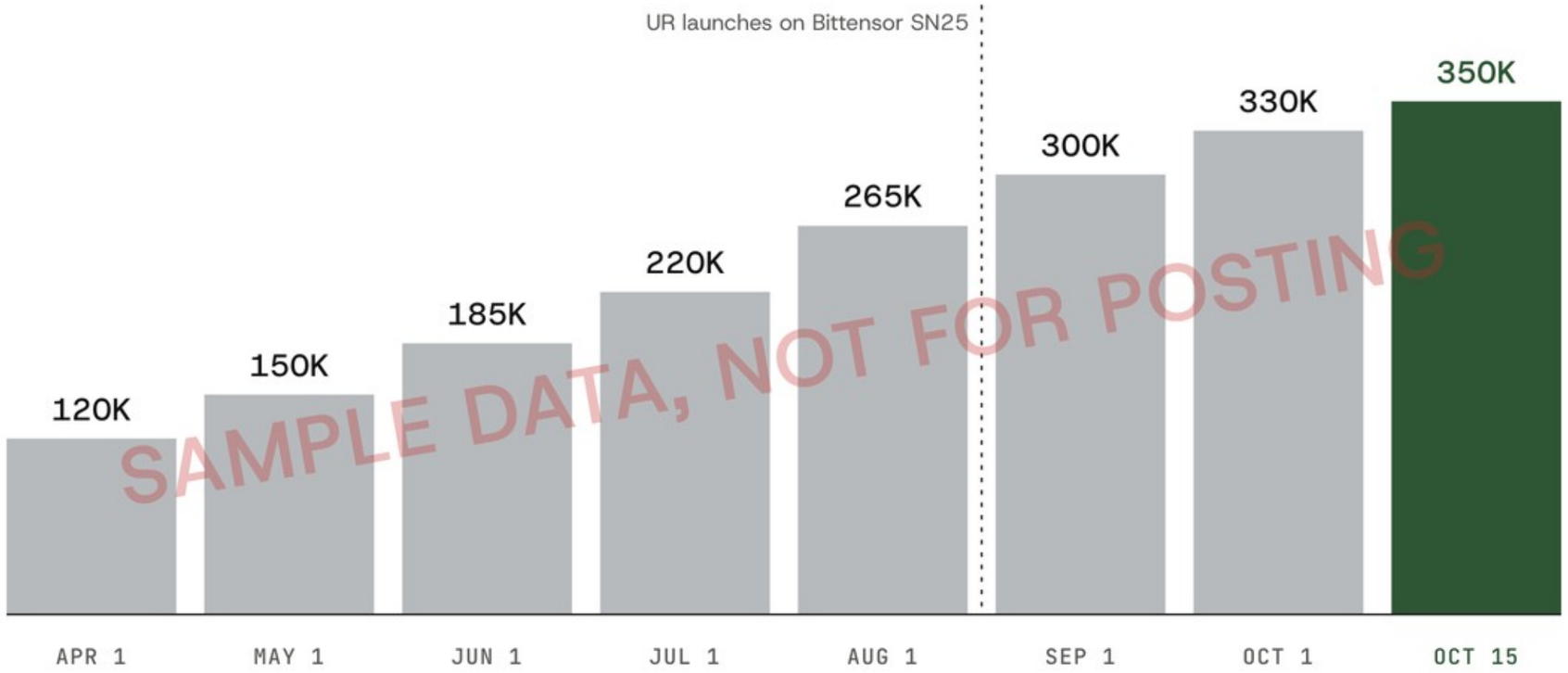
Monthly active users of the URnetwork VPN, first day of each month (team-reported).

126,717

providers across 103 countries

The user base already exists while the deposit rate is still zero, so the open question for SN25 is pricing rather than demand.

Each month of growth enlarges the base that operator deposits will be sized against once the reference rate is set.

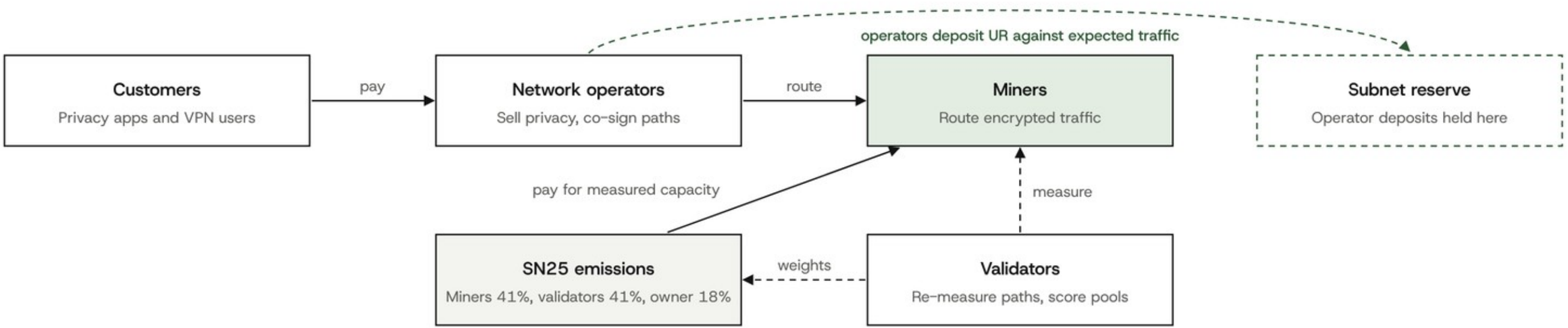


SAMPLE DATA, NOT FOR POSTING

Monthly active users and providers are team-reported. Source: URnetwork.

UR pays miners only for routing capacity that Bittensor validators have independently measured

Customers pay operators, operators route traffic through miners, and validators verify the work before emissions are paid.



Solid lines run today. Dashed lines are measurement, weights and the deposit link, which switches on once the reference rate is above zero. Deposits

126,717	103	~200	$8.4M
Providers on URnetwork (team-reported)	Countries covered (team-reported)	Top-level miner fleets, ranked by distinct exit IPs	SN25 market cap, mid-October 2026

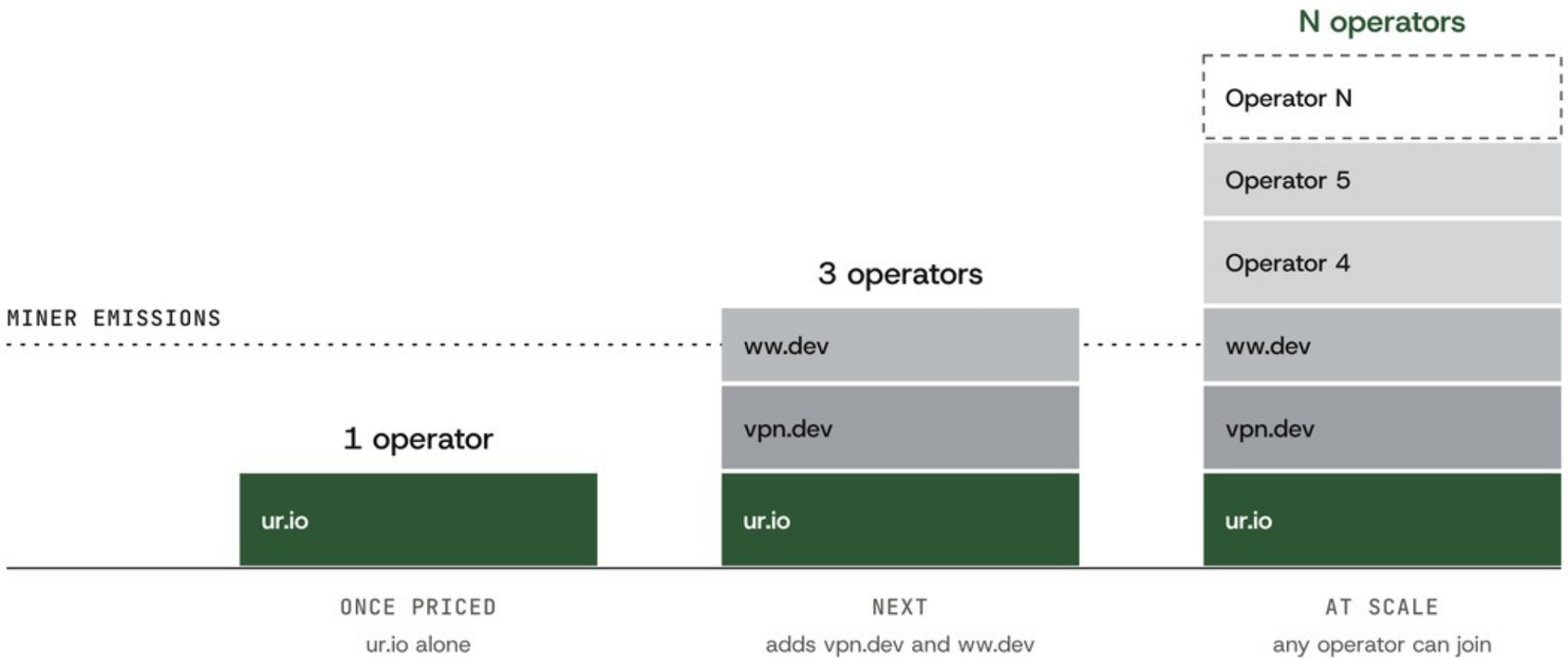
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Every new operator on UR becomes a structural buyer of SN25

Once deposits are priced, operators must acquire and lock SN25 in proportion to the users and data they serve.

Above the dotted line, operators buy more SN25 than miners receive in emissions.

Deposits sit in a reserve that never pays out, so every unit purchased leaves circulating supply permanently. Where the line sits depends on the reference rate UR sets.



Illustrative, not a forecast. The deposit rate is zero today and UR has not yet set prices. Mechanism: UR SN25 architecture (September 2026); UR Foundation SN25 repository.

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At Helium's valuation SN25 would be a 10x, and at Grass's a 58x

URnetwork already reports about 350K monthly users, yet SN25 is valued at $8.4M, below both comparable networks whose customers pay for capacity.

A wide valuation gap

Transaction-privacy assets are valued at about $31B, against roughly $46M for the five network-privacy tokens we track, a gap of around 670 times.

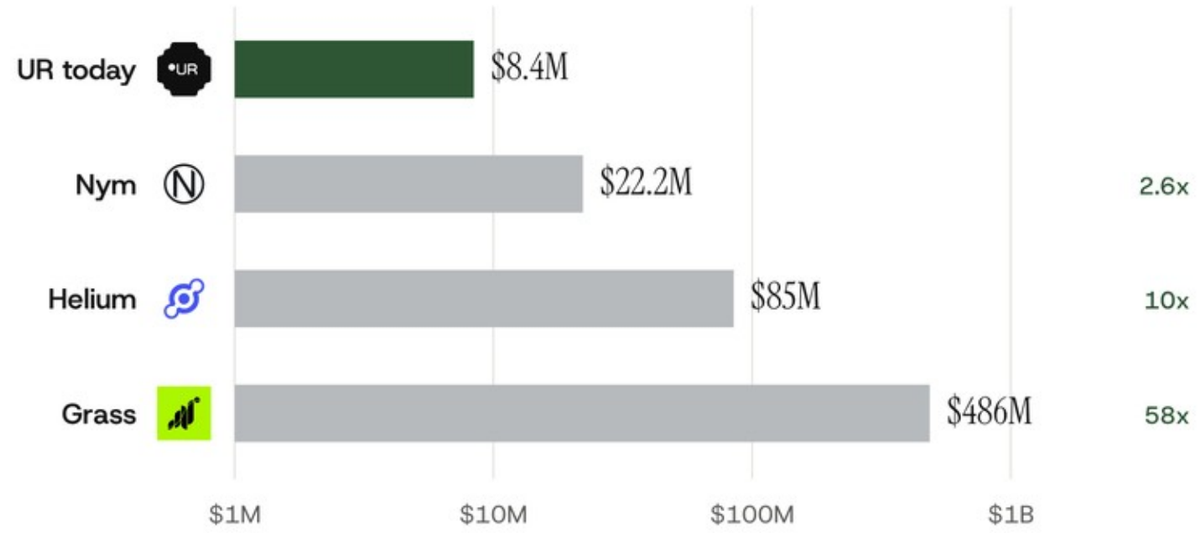
A product already in market

URnetwork, the VPN that SN25 supplies, reports about 350K monthly users and 126,717 providers across 103 countries, so the thesis does not depend on a product launch.

Demand linked to usage

Once the deposit rate rises above zero, operators must acquire and permanently lock UR in proportion to their traffic, converting customer growth into token demand. Until then, TAO inflows fund supply.

What UR would be worth at its peers' market caps



Market cap, USD, log scale. CoinGecko and MEXC, 15 October 2026. Multiples compare market caps today and are illustrative, not price targets.

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UR holders receive no revenue today, and the token depends on TAO inflows until operators begin paying

The litepaper excludes any right to profits, and the operator deposit rate starts at zero.



How value reaches SN25, most likely first

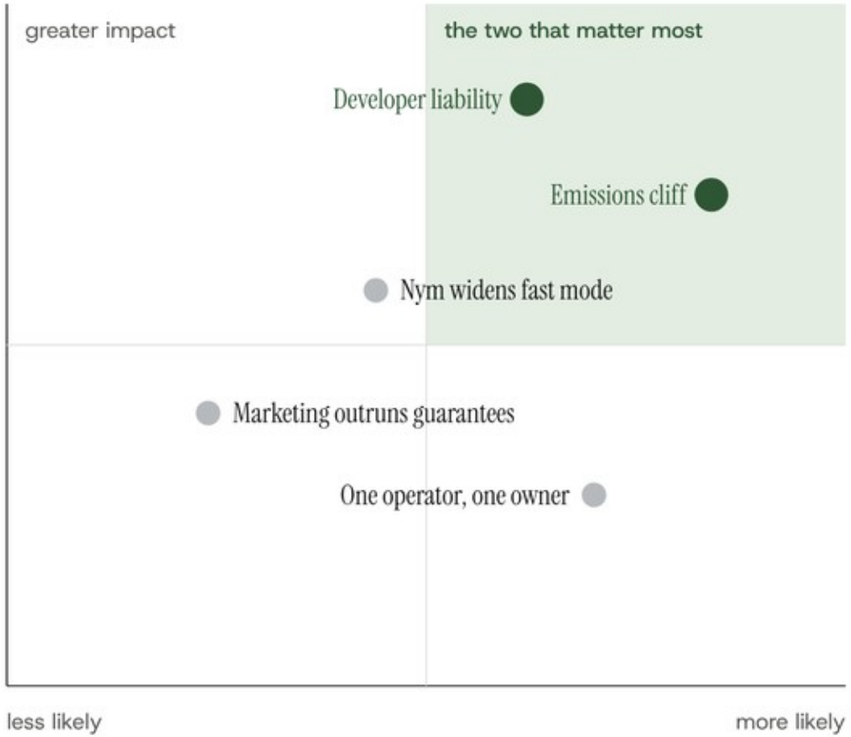
1	**TAO inflows** Bittensor sets each subnet's emissions by its net TAO inflows over about three months, so staking into SN25 lifts emissions and alpha demand.	Live since November 2025	Breaks if: net outflows cut emissions and miner pay together.
2	**Sector re-rating** SN25 trades as Bittensor's privacy exposure while capital rotates into the category.	Live	Breaks if: the most reversible pathway; a ZEC drawdown would likely drag it.
3	**Operator deposits** Operators acquire UR to deposit against traffic, and deposits stay in the reserve rather than returning to circulation.	Rate set to zero at launch	Breaks if: the rate stays at zero, or operators never arrive.
4	**Reserve governance** Future onchain governance could direct how the reserve is used.	Speculative; no proposal	Breaks if: the owner controls the contract until it hardens.

Ranked by likelihood. The deposit pathway is the one that turns UR from a subsidised network into a paid one.

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A court ruling and staker outflows are the two risks capable of breaking the UR thesis

The Storm retrial is scheduled for April 2027, while stakers can withdraw from SN25 at any time.



Risk	What would have to happen	Signal to watch
Developer liability	Roman Storm's retrial on the laundering and sanctions counts, set for 26 April 2027, ends in a conviction and reopens exposure for privacy developers.	Rulings on the pending acquittal motion; the retrial verdict
Emissions cliff	Stakers pull TAO from SN25 before deposits begin, and miner pay and exit coverage shrink together.	Net TAO flow into SN25, month by month
Nym widens fast mode	Nym, with a VPN, a16z backing and rewards moving to real traffic, takes the operators UR needs.	Nym's browser and wallet integrations
Marketing outruns guarantees	URnetwork markets Tor-like anonymity while UR claims no defence against a global observer, and a public deanonymisation lands.	Independent audits of URnetwork's privacy claims
One operator, one owner	BringYour stays the only operator, the owner stays the largest validator, and its multisig keeps control of settlement with no upgrade timelock yet.	A second operator; the timelock going live

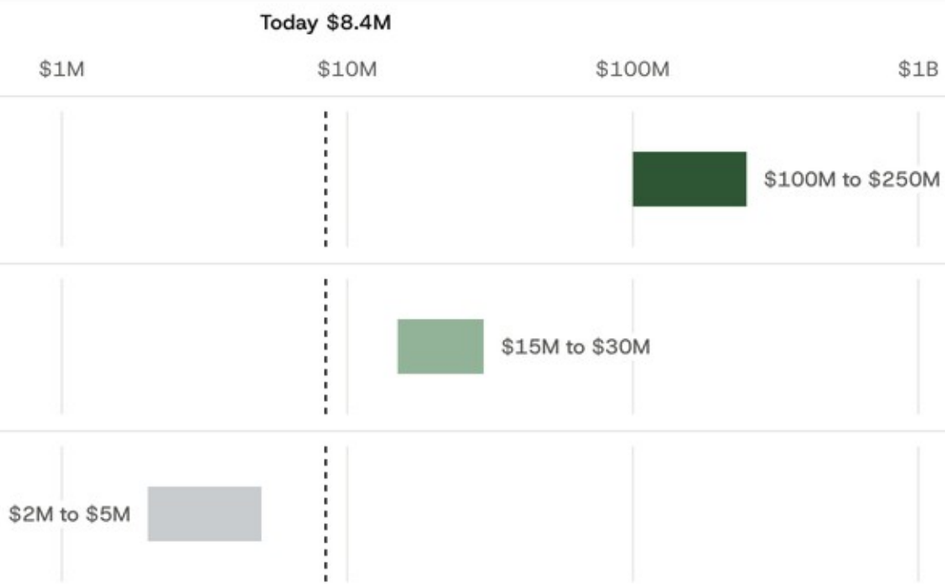
Khala Research judgement of likelihood and impact.

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Our base case implies 1.8 to 3.6x by the end of 2027, and our bull case 12 to 30x

The outcome turns on a single variable, operator deposits on SN25, which are zero today.

Scenario	What has to happen	From today
Bull	Wallets and privacy apps buy capacity, and operator deposits reach a quarter of miner emissions.	12x to 30x
Base	Deposits switch on in 2027, and two to four operators pay small amounts.	1.8x to 3.6x
Bear	The deposit rate stays at zero, there is still one operator, and TAO flows out of SN25.	-76% to -40%



The number to watch

Monthly operator deposits on SN25. The first non-zero deposit moves UR out of the bear case, and deposits worth a quarter of miner emissions put it in the bull case.

Implied SN25 market cap by end 2027, log scale. Illustrative ranges, not forecasts or investment advice.

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Seven dated events and signals will determine how these tokens trade into 2027

Key catalysts for each token in our coverage universe, in expected order.

When	Token	Event	Why it matters
13 Nov 2026	**Aztec**	Foundation token unlock	Adds supply while user funds secured are still under $100K
Late 2026	**Aztec**	Version 6 fixes the critical proving bug	Aztec asked teams to pause new deployments until then
Coming soon	**Umbra**	Nimbus developer network and SDK	First sign that other apps will route fees to Umbra
When priced	**SN25 UR**	First operator deposit	Turns users into SN25 buying; the rate is zero today
Quarterly	**Zcash**	Shielded share and US ETF holdings	Shows whether demand to hold is turning into private use
No date	**PersistentAI**	A token or a named bank customer	Nothing to own until one of these happens
26 Apr 2027	**All five**	Roman Storm retrial on laundering and sanctions counts	A conviction would raise legal risk for every privacy developer

Unlock date: Tokenomist. Aztec v6: Aztec, 7 August 2026. Storm retrial: The Block, 26 August 2026.

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APPENDIX

Supporting analysis

Supporting analysis referred to in the main report.

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A single linked address exposes a company's payroll, supplier terms and treasury activity to its competitors

An illustrative month of stablecoin payments at a fictional company, as a competitor would see it.

Corporates do not need secrecy from auditors or regulators; they need control over who can read their records.

Under controlled disclosure the network still verifies every payment, while the amounts and counterparties are visible only to the company, its auditor and its regulators.

Payment	What the public ledger shows	What a competitor learns	What the public sees with controlled disclosure
Salaries	Three transfers totalling $29,450 on the 25th of each month	Headcount and individual pay	Three payments of [redacted] to [redacted] Verified
Supplier invoice	$184,000 to an address analytics tools label Kestrel Components	The main supplier, its price and terms	One payment of [redacted] to [redacted] Verified
Customer receipt	$420,000 in from an address labelled Orion Retail	A key customer and the contract size	One receipt of [redacted] from [redacted] Verified
Treasury transfer	$2.4M to an exchange deposit address	A likely sale, before it settles	One transfer of [redacted] to [redacted] Verified

Fictional company, names and amounts, for illustration.

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FORCE ONE

Exposure gets cheaper

Models parse transaction histories at a scale that once took analysts weeks, so watching a public ledger costs close to nothing.

FORCE TWO

Private data gets more valuable

Useful assistants need email, records and preferences to work, so people and companies disclose more to them.

Demand for computation that uses data without exposing it

NEAR AI Cloud Live

Confidential inference since December 2025

Nillion Building

Multi-party computation, backed by Hack VC

Seismic Building

Secure hardware, backed by a16z

AI lowers the cost of surveilling public ledgers while raising the value of the data they expose

Both forces increase the cost of operating in public.

"For users that prioritize privacy, this could become a 'must-have' feature."

Zach Pandl, Head of Research, Grayscale, September 2026

Grayscale's view is that AI adoption will lift demand for financial privacy.

Only five of the 18 privacy projects we track protect who the user is

Each project sits in the layer it protects. At the network layer, only UR and Nym ensure that no single server sees both ends of a connection.

Hides who you are

5 projects

Network

Your IP and who you talk to

- **UR (SN25)** — Mesh routing
- **Nym** — Mixnet
- **Orchid** — Bandwidth market
- **Sentinel** — Decentralised VPN
- **Mysterium** — Decentralised VPN

Hides what you send

13 projects

Computation

App and AI inputs

- **NEAR AI** — Secure hardware
- **Seismic** — Secure hardware
- **Nillion** — Multi-party compute
- **Zama** — Encrypted compute
- **Nockchain** Early — ZK proof of work

Applications

Contract state and activity

- **Fhenix** — Encrypted compute
- **Aztec** — ZK rollup
- **Aleo** — ZK layer 1

Payments and assets

Balances and counterparties

- **Zcash** — Shielded pool
- **Railgun** — Shielded pool
- **Privacy Pools** — Shielded pool
- **Umbra** Nimbus — Solana wallet
- **USAD** — Private stablecoin

Khala Research classification by the main thing each project hides; several projects combine techniques.

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PersistentAI sells confidential AI agents to banks, but offers no investable token

We include it because private data is a precondition for AI agents inside financial institutions, but for investors it remains a monitoring item rather than a position.

What it sells

FireFlow, software for running AI agents inside a bank: memory, permissions, approvals and replayable audit trails.

The privacy angle

Models can run on the institution's own servers, so customer data, transactions and documents stay inside its perimeter.

Who pays

Financial institutions, after a four-week assessment and a staged rollout. There is no public pricing, revenue or named customer.

The team

Founded by a former hedge fund quant and risk manager, a CTO who co-founded Blum, and a strategist from the Chiliz ecosystem.

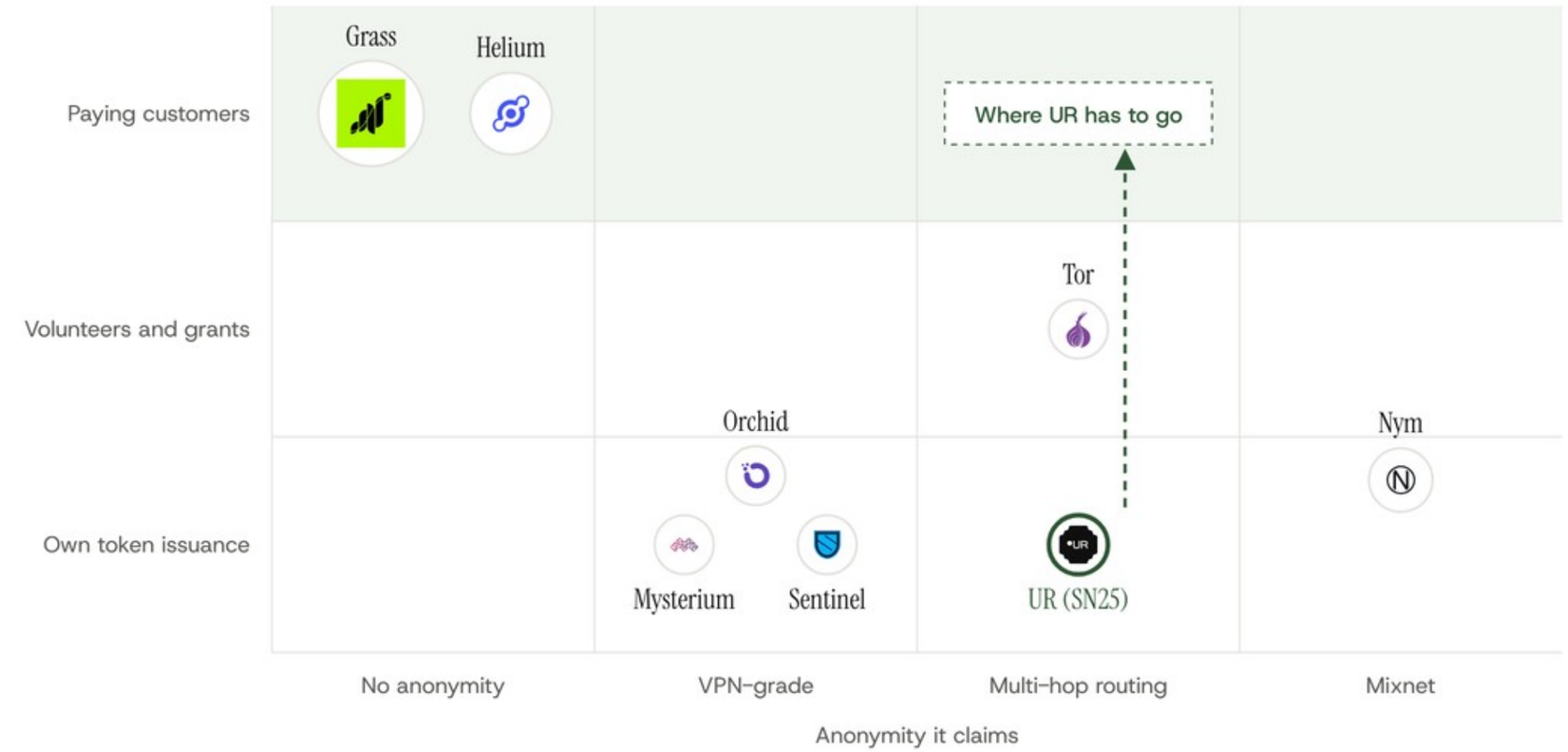
Token status

We found no native token. A link to Aztec has been suggested but not confirmed, and would cover settlement rather than agent data.

What would make it investable

A token with a clear claim on fees, a named bank in production, or a confirmed onchain settlement layer.

Source: persistentai.org, accessed 16 October 2026. Not affiliated with PersistentAI Ltd (persistentai.ai), a separate UK company.



Circle size: market cap, CoinGecko and MEXC, 15 October 2026. Tor has no token.

Nym offers stronger anonymity guarantees, so UR must compete on network reach and price

UR's central challenge is establishing who pays for its supply.

Nym combines stronger anonymity with its own VPN, so UR is better positioned as a complement than as a replacement.

Networks funded by their own token issuance cluster at the bottom of this chart; Grass and Helium moved up by securing paying customers.

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Sources and notes

Market data is as of mid-October 2026 and will change. Verify live figures before acting on this analysis.

Deployments reported only by the companies involved are labelled. Scenario ranges are illustrative judgements, not forecasts.

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DefiLlama stablecoins and DeFi TVL, 15 Oct 2026

The Block US spot ETF net assets, 10 Oct 2026

rwa.xyz tokenised asset distributed value, 14 Oct 2026

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TechCrunch Telegram passes 1B users (19 Mar 2025)

The Block Zcash shielded supply (26 Dec 2025); Ethereum Foundation Privacy Cluster (Oct 2025); Storm retrial (26 Aug 2026)

Blockworks Advisory Zcash token holder report Q2 2026, funded by GenZcash

CoinDesk Research Encryption Supremacy (31 Mar 2026), sponsored by GenZcash

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NEAR AI NEAR AI Cloud and Private Chat (3 Dec 2025)

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Willkie Farr Tornado Cash delisting (Mar 2025)

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Bitrue Grass revenue, team-reported (30 Sep 2026)

crypto.news / Blockworks Helium data credit burn (Jun 2026)

CoinCarp Zorp seed round (aggregator)

Umbra umbraprivacy.com and docs; DefiLlama market data (15 Oct 2026)

Crucible Labs URnetwork monthly users, self-reported (21 Aug 2026)

The Daily Hodl Zach Pandl, Grayscale (2 Sep 2026)

UR Foundation SN25 subnet repository on GitHub

Aztec Alpha v5 and vulnerability notice (21 Jul and 7 Aug 2026); token page

L2BEAT Aztec Network: value secured, sequencers, staking, risks (16 Oct 2026)

CoinDesk; Tokenomist AZTEC price, supply and unlocks (14 Oct 2026)

Bex Aztec token sale and timeline (13 Mar 2026)

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PersistentAI persistentai.org and investor page (accessed 16 Oct 2026)

Jack Leung, Khala Research Privacy token landscape (Oct 2026)